were well below freezing. Yet, somehow, the two battalions had arrived at Tsangdhar by 5 p.m. on 7 October, within the stipulated time set by the corps commander. However, at Tsangdhar, there was no shelter for the men; being above the treeline, even finding fuel to light a fire was a problem. For the second successive night, the men had to camp out in the open at an altitude of over 14,500 feet. In the absence of warm clothing, tents and bedding, the men bivouacked by sharing—two men huddled together with one blanket below and another wrapped around them. With temperatures plummeting to minus 10 degrees Celsius for the second night in succession, a number of soldiers from both the battalions had to be evacuated due to exposure and pulmonary oedema. Four Gorkha soldiers died during this march to Tsangdhar.

In the meantime, the engineer detachment at Lumpu had worked through the night with Petromaxes to prepare a helipad for Kaul at Serkhim. The corps commander, accompanied by GOC 4 Division, Major General Niranjan Prasad, had landed there on the morning of 6 October. After spending time with CO 9 Punjab and the battalion at Serkhim, the general had been carried piggyback across Hathung-la to Bridge 1 by a local Monpa. The rather unusual sight of the corps commander arriving at the Nam Ka Chu in this undignified manner was Kaul's introduction to the men of 7 Brigade who were deployed at Bridge 1. By 2.30 p.m., Dalvi, along with his two commanding officers, made his way from Tsangdhar to Bridge 1 via Bridge 3 and 2. This was to be Dalvi's first meeting with the corps commander who had by then moved the entire brigade to the Nam Ka Chu. Dalvi asked Prasad, his immediate boss, what orders he had for the two newly arrived battalions that were then assembling below Tsangdhar DZ. Niranjan Prasad confessed that he had no clue, as the entire operational plan was under Kaul's personal control.

ROMMEL OF THE HIGH HIMALAYAS

Kaul used the next thirty-six hours to mull over his various options while sending out lengthy signals to Delhi. First, he would lay out the stark reality of the situation on the ground, but then sign off with grandiose claims that he, Kaul, had the situation under control and he would indeed evict the Chinese. Neither the GOC nor the brigade commander had a clue as to what strategy was brewing inside Kaul's head. All this while he would also talk at length about German Field Marshal Erwin Rommel's hooks and